

CASTLES

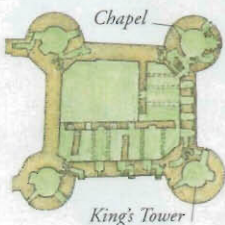


IN MEDIEVAL EUROPE, castles acted as both home and military stronghold. They were occupied by a lord, his family, servants, and sometimes an army of professional soldiers. They provided refuge for local people in times of war. Local lords could control the surrounding land from their castles, hence they were a very important part of feudalism. Castles were built to be defended, with walls strong enough to keep out an enemy, while allowing the occupants to shoot at any attackers. Designs changed as builders invented better methods of defence, or adapted new ideas from castles in the Islamic world.



The King's Tower

This room on the first floor, close to the royal apartments has a stone fireplace and a recessed window. The recess means a person looking out remains safe from any enemy fire. The original floors have been removed.



King's Tower

Parts of a castle

Early castles had a keep, which contained the lord's rooms, hall, chapel, storerooms, and a well-defended gatehouse. Later castles abandoned the keep, and replaced it with a Great Hall, which was built against the castle walls. The lord's rooms were sometimes built into the gatehouse, but in Conwy they are in the Inner Ward, which was the heart of the castle, and most easily defended.



North-west Tower

Outer Ward

The Great Hall was the centre of activity. There was a high table for the lord and lady, and lower tables for everyone else.

The Kitchen was where food for the whole castle was prepared. There were wood fires, oak tables, and alcoves.

The Stockhouse Tower got its name when stocks for prisoners were made here in the 1500s.

The Inner Ward was the last refuge in time of attack.

Machicolations, or overhanging parapets, allowed defenders to pour boiling water on their opponents.

Chapel Tower

The Prison Tower had a deep, dark dungeon.

Bakehouse Tower

King's Tower

Conwy Castle, Wales, in the 13th century

The East Barbican was the first line of defence against attack by sea, and was also a good position from which to fire. Defenders could isolate the enemy in this area.

Lookout Tower

Timeline

1066 The Normans erect wooden motte-and-bailey castles during the conquest of England. These are quick to build, and the motte, or tower on top of a mound, is easy to defend. Most buildings are in the bailey, or courtyard.

Krak des Chevaliers, Syria

1142 Krak des Chevaliers built in Syria; one of the most easy-to-defend crusader castles, has concentric stone walls.



1127 Rochester Castle built: includes a great hall, chapel, and storerooms. The entrance is well protected, and defenders can shoot at attackers.

Great Tower, Rochester, England



1150 Many French lords build castles along the River Loire. Examples built (or extended) during this period include Loches, Chinon, and Montreuil-Bellay.

1200 The German lords of Liechtenstein build their castle on a high crag for extra defence.

Caerphilly, Wales

1238 The Muslim rulers of medieval Spain begin the castle-palace of the Alhambra.

1271 Concentric castles, like Caerphilly, become popular. They have rings of walls and sometimes water defences (moats).

